



and aggressive about disinvestment?

A: We have not changed the philosophy... After all, the public sector enterprises policy was part of my Budget speech of 2021. And we continue to be on that [disinvestment] route because that was approved in Parliament... You have to do a lot of preparatory work for each company with each department and prime it and only then can it go into the market. And unique issues need to be sorted out for each one. And the first one that I will ensure is that nothing wrong goes into the deal... [for the] workers who are in it, their work conditions, their safety, their continuity in the job and so on... That is only one unique situation, but several situations that are unique to each problem are reasons why you have to take more time. Other than of course choosing your time to go to the market.

Many of the companies that deal with public money still don't have professional managerial structures. Governance within them is to run the company well. But they don't have what is required to be taken to the market. I'm not faulting them. The work culture over the last 70 years has been to run the company, give dividend to the government, and take care of your workers. I'm saying do all that and do something more. And that something more is make your institution have some fundamental things... First, within com-

panies, some don't even have a mechanism to value them. We had to spend a lot of time to get them (these valuation mechanisms) in place. And that takes time... sometimes it takes a full year. The long and short of it is we are on course; we will be doing it (disinvestment). Between the last year and now, there are quite a few things that have happened. So, we are on course.

SM: The Economic Survey talks about the tripartite compact between the private sector, the centre and the state governments to work together. In light of what happened at the recent NITI Aayog meeting, how optimistic are you that states, especially where the opposition parties are in power, will co-operate?

A: I'm very optimistic. It's one thing that many of the opposition party-led governments did not come for the NITI Aayog meeting... but I am very confident that aside from all this filibustering, states and the centre will work together on most things. There can always be a situation where there will be friction... But otherwise, I found that working together with states, particularly the officials who come and work for the actual nitty gritty of the whole thing, things do go very well. **BT**

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